

Sec 2 Literature Cheat Sheet

Both sections of the EOY paper: *Emily of Emerald Hill* by Stella Kon (Section A, 25 marks) and unseen poetry (Section B, 25 marks). Plot, characters, themes, drama and poetry techniques, how to write each answer, and practice questions with model answers.

Emily: the play Section A · context, form, plot · 6 topics

The paper at a glance

EXAM

SECTION	TEXT	MARKS	WHAT YOU DO
A	<i>Emily of Emerald Hill</i> (Stella Kon)	25	Answer one question: an essay question or a passage-based question on a printed extract
B	Unseen poetry	25	Read a poem you have never seen and answer both parts

- **Time:** the two sections are worth the same, so give them the same time. Spend the first 5 minutes of each reading and planning
- **Every paragraph** needs a point, a short quote, an explanation of the word choice, and a link back to the question
- Write about **the writer's choices**: "Kon shows...", "The poet uses...", not just what happens

Watch out: retelling the story earns very few marks. Every sentence should answer "how" or "why", not "what happens next".

Context: who wrote it, when and why it matters

CONTEXT

- **Playwright:** Stella Kon, a Singaporean writer. She began the play in 1982 and it won first prize at the **1983 National Playwriting Competition**
- **First staged:** 1984 in Seremban, Malaysia (actress Leow Puay Tin), then at the 1985 Singapore Drama Festival with **Margaret Chan** as Emily
- **Inspiration:** Kon's grandmother, who lived in a house called Oberon on Emerald Hill. Kon said she was the model for Emily's *character*, but not for the events of her life
- **Setting:** Emily's big family house, Oberon, on **Emerald Hill** (off Orchard Road), from 1929 to Emily's old age in modern Singapore
- **Peranakan world:** Straits Chinese families who mixed Chinese and Malay culture: Baba Malay language, sarong kebaya, nyonya food, large households run by a matriarch
- It is often called Singapore's **most-staged play** and a landmark of Singapore theatre in English

USING CONTEXT IN AN ANSWER

Link it to a point, in one sentence: "In a 1930s Peranakan family, a wife's worth came from serving her husband's family, so Emily's careful pleasing of her mother-in-law is how she gains security and power."

Watch out: don't write a history paragraph. One sentence of context, tied to the question, is enough.

Form and structure: a one-woman play

FORM

- **Monodrama:** one actress plays Emily for the whole play. Every other character (husband, children, mother-in-law, servants, guests) is unseen. We only hear Emily's side of every conversation
- **Direct address:** Emily speaks to the audience as if we were her guests, friends or family. We are drawn in and become her listeners
- **Flashbacks and time shifts:** the play moves back and forth in time instead of telling the story in order

PART	TIME	WHAT WE SEE
Act 1 opens	1950	Emily at her peak: capable manager of the house, fond mother, society hostess
Act 1 flashback	1920s–1929	Her childhood and early marriage: how powerless and vulnerable she once was
Act 2 opens	late 1950s	Then flashes back to her "glory days" of the early 1930s
Act 2 returns	late 1950s	Cooking babi buah keluak; Kheong tries to break away; the family crisis
Final scene	old age	In modern Singapore her memory drifts free of time and rewrites the past as she wished it had been

Effect of the structure: like meeting a new friend, we learn Emily's story in pieces, and the most private details come last. We admire her first, then understand *why* she needs control, then see what it costs.

Watch out: because we only hear Emily, she is an **unreliable narrator**. Say "Emily claims..." or "Emily presents herself as..." when her version may not be the whole truth.

Plot in order (what really happened)

PLOT

1. **Childhood:** Emily's father dies. When she is about 10, her mother leaves her, complaining that she has only a "useless" daughter and no son. Emily is passed between relatives
2. **1929, age 14:** she marries her cousin **Kheong**, about twice her age, and moves into the wealthy Gan household at Oberon, Emerald Hill
3. **Winning the house:** she pleases her mother-in-law (making tea, preparing betel leaves, massaging her at card games) and is rewarded with a diamond ring. Step by step she takes over running the household
4. **Matriarch and hostess:** by the 1930s–1950s she is a famous hostess and the real power in the family. Children: **Richard** (eldest, her favourite), Edward, Charlie and **Doris**
5. **Kheong drifts away:** her husband has a mistress, Diana Lee, and spends time at her house on Amber Road. Emily fights to keep him and her position
6. **Richard:** sent to study in England, he leaves university and works at a riding school in Salisbury. Emily goes to London to bring him back to her plans. Unable to live the life she has planned for him, Richard takes his own life
7. **Doris:** wants to marry an American, Steve Jackson. This time Emily lets her go: she has learnt that love means letting go
8. **Old age:** Emily, alone in a changed, modern Singapore, remembers and rewrites her past

Watch out: the play does not show these in this order (see Form and structure). In an essay, refer to moments by what happens ("when Emily goes to London..."), not by page number.

Peranakan culture and language in the play

CULTURE

WORD OR DETAIL	MEANING	WHY IT MATTERS
Nyonya / Baba	Peranakan woman / man	Emily's identity as a proud nyonya
Baba Malay	Peranakan language mixing Malay and Hokkien	Emily switches between English and Baba Malay: shows her world and her many roles
Sarong kebaya	traditional embroidered blouse and sarong	costume that marks her status and tradition
Babi buah keluak	pork cooked with black keluak nuts	Emily's cooking shows skill and control; food is how she wins love and loyalty
Sireh (betel leaves)	chewed by older nyonyas	preparing it for her mother-in-law shows how she pleases those with power
The house, Oberon	big family home on Emerald Hill	her kingdom: the space she controls

- Food, festivals, clothes and family rules show a **traditional world that is fading** by the end, as Singapore modernises and her children look to the West

Watch out: don't just list cultural details. Say what each one shows about Emily (status, control, love, change).

Drama terms to use in answers

TERMS

TERM	MEANING	EXAMPLE IN EMILY
Monologue / monodrama	one character speaks; one-actor play	the whole play
Direct address	character speaks straight to the audience	Emily treats us as guests and confidants
Flashback	scene set earlier in time	childhood, early marriage, the 1930s
Dramatic irony	audience knows more than the character	we see her control pushing Richard away before she does
Characterisation	how a writer builds a character	Emily's commands, flattery and boasting

Tone	the feeling in how something is said	bossy, charming, proud, bitter, regretful
Props and stage directions	objects and instructions for performance	food, the diamond ring, her kebaya
Foreshadowing	hint of what will come	her need to control hints at the loss of Richard

Watch out: naming a term earns nothing on its own. Always add its **effect**: "The direct address makes the audience feel like Emily's confidants, so we sympathise with her even when she is manipulative."

Emily: characters & themes Section A · who's who and the big ideas · 4 topics

Emily Gan

CHARACTER

Emily is a poor, unwanted girl who becomes the powerful **matriarch** of a rich Peranakan family, and pays for her success with the love of those closest to her.

TRAIT	EVIDENCE (MOMENT TO QUOTE)	EFFECT ON THE AUDIENCE
Determined, clever	wins over her mother-in-law step by step and takes over the household	we admire her survival skills
Controlling, manipulative	gives orders to servants and family; plans her children's futures	we laugh at first, then grow uneasy
Insecure	rejected by her own mother as a "useless" daughter	explains her need to be needed; makes her sympathetic
Loving but possessive	her devotion to Richard; her trip to London	tragic: her love becomes the thing that destroys
Capable of change	lets Doris marry the man she chooses	gives her redemption and the audience hope

Her own philosophy: if a woman's only value is as a wife and mother, then be "the very devil of a wife and mother" so that everyone depends on you. This one line explains her whole life.

Watch out: Emily is not simply a villain or a victim. The best answers show **both**: she is shaped by a system that devalued girls, and she then uses that system to control others.

The other characters (all unseen)

CHARACTER

CHARACTER	WHO	WHAT THEY SHOW ABOUT EMILY
Kheong	husband and cousin, about twice her age	her striving pushes him away; he turns to his mistress Diana Lee
Richard	eldest son, her favourite	her love becomes control; his death is the play's tragedy
Doris	daughter	Emily learns to let go; also shows her old-fashioned views (girls must learn to cook)
Mother-in-law	head of the Gan household when Emily arrives	Emily learns power by pleasing her, then takes her place
Emily's mother	abandons Emily as a child	source of Emily's insecurity; shows sons valued over daughters
Diana Lee	Kheong's mistress (Amber Road)	a threat to Emily's position as wife
Edward, Charlie	younger sons	part of the family Emily runs

Because the actress plays all of these through Emily's voice, we only ever get **Emily's version** of them.

Watch out: spell the names right: **Kheong, Doris, Richard**, and the playwright **Stella Kon** ("Kon" in essays, not "Stella").

Key themes

THEMES

THEME	WHAT KON SHOWS	KEY MOMENTS
Power and control	a powerless girl gains power by pleasing, then managing, everyone. Control brings success but ruins relationships	mother-in-law and the diamond ring; running the house; Richard
Women's roles and patriarchy	girls were valued less than sons; women gained power only as wives and mothers. Emily works within the system and passes on its rules	her mother's rejection; "devil of a wife and mother"; telling Doris to learn to cook
Identity and roles	Emily plays many parts: daughter-in-law, hostess, matriarch, mother, grandmother. She is always performing	switching tone with each unseen listener
Love versus control	true love means letting go	Richard (holding on → tragedy) vs Doris (letting go → redemption)

Loneliness and the cost of success	the woman everyone needed ends up alone	Kheong leaves; Richard dies; old age
Tradition and change	the Peranakan world fades as Singapore modernises and the children look West	England, America, the final scene
Memory	Emily rewrites the past to protect herself	final scene; the time shifts

Watch out: name the theme *and* say what Kon is saying about it. "The theme is power" is weak; "Kon shows that power gained through control leaves Emily lonely" is strong.

Key moments to learn quotes for

QUOTES

Pick **3-4 short quotes** (under 10 words each) from your own copy of the play for each row. Short quotes are easier to remember and analyse.

MOMENT	USE IT FOR
Emily's mother rejecting her as a "useless" daughter	insecurity; sons valued over daughters; sympathy
Arriving at Oberon as a 14-year-old bride	powerlessness; her starting point
Pleasing her mother-in-law; the diamond ring	cleverness; how power is won
Giving orders as hostess and housekeeper (opening, 1950)	control; confidence; performance
"the very devil of a wife and mother"	her philosophy; women's roles; power
Cooking babi buah keluak	skill; food as love and control
Kheong and Diana Lee	cost of striving; her fear of losing position
Going to London for Richard; his death	love turning into control; tragedy
Letting Doris marry Steve Jackson	change; letting go; redemption
The final scene in old age	loneliness; memory; tradition and change

HOW TO ANALYSE A QUOTE

Zoom in on **one word**: what does it suggest? Then the effect: "The word 'devil' suggests Emily knows her methods are ruthless, yet she embraces them, showing how desperate she is to be needed."

Watch out: copy quotes **exactly** from the text, with quotation marks. A misquoted line, or a quote with no comment on its words, loses marks.

How to write the essay question

ESSAY

1. **Underline the key words** in the question (e.g. "how", "powerful", "to what extent")
2. **Plan for 5 minutes:** 3 points, each with a moment and a quote. Order them from beginning to end of Emily's life, or weakest to strongest
3. **Introduction** (2–3 lines): answer the question directly and name your 3 ideas
4. **3 body paragraphs** using **PEEL**: Point → Evidence (quote) → Explain (word choice + effect on the audience) → Link to the question
5. **Conclusion** (2–3 lines): your overall answer, plus what Kon wants the audience to think or feel

MODEL PARAGRAPH: "HOW DOES KON PRESENT EMILY AS A POWERFUL WOMAN?"

Kon shows that Emily's power comes from making others depend on her [point]. She sums up her own philosophy: a woman should be "the very devil of a wife and mother" [evidence]. The word "devil" suggests that Emily knows her methods are ruthless, yet she says it with pride, showing that power matters more to her than being liked [explain]. Since a woman in her world had value only as a wife and mother, she turns those roles into weapons [context]. This shows that Emily's power is real but built on control rather than love [link].

Watch out: "To what extent" means give **both sides**, then a clear judgement. Don't sit on the fence.

How to write the passage-based question

PASSAGE

1. **Place the extract:** one or two sentences on where it comes in the play and what has just happened
2. **Read twice:** first for what happens, second to underline 4–5 striking words, stage directions or changes in tone
3. **Answer in PEEL paragraphs**, taking quotes **from the extract**. Work through it in order so you don't miss the ending
4. **Notice performance:** stage directions, pauses, who Emily is speaking to, shifts in time, and how the audience would react
5. **Widen out** (if the question asks about the play as a whole): link the extract to one other moment

LOOK FOR

ASK YOURSELF

Commands and questions	is Emily in control here, or trying to be?
Change in tone	where does she switch from charming to sharp, or proud to sad? Why?
Stage directions	what does the actress do, and what does that show?
Who she is talking to	how does she change her manner for each listener?

Watch out: stay with the extract. Most of your quotes must come from the printed passage, not from memory.

Practice questions on Emily

PRACTICE

How does Kon present Emily as a powerful woman? (Essay)

Plan:

1. She gains power cleverly: pleasing her mother-in-law until she is rewarded (the diamond ring) and takes over the house
2. She keeps power through control: the commanding hostess of 1950, running servants, food and family
3. Her power has limits and a cost: Kheong leaves for Diana Lee, Richard dies, and she ends alone

Judgement: Kon presents Emily as very powerful inside the home, but shows that power built on control cannot hold the people she loves.

Marking tip: top answers show that Emily's power is limited to the home and comes at a cost, not just that she is "strong".

To what extent is Emily a sympathetic character? (Essay)

Sympathetic: abandoned by her mother as a "useless" daughter; married at 14; lives in a world that values only sons and obedient wives; her direct address makes us her confidants.

Not sympathetic: she manipulates her mother-in-law and husband; her control of Richard leads to tragedy; she passes old-fashioned rules to Doris.

Judgement: largely sympathetic, because Kon shows *why* she became controlling, and she grows when she lets Doris go.

Marking tip: you must argue both sides and end with a clear judgement and a reason.

Explore how Kon presents the relationship between Emily and Richard. (Essay)

1. **Deep love:** Richard is her favourite and her hope for the family's future.

2. **Love becomes control:** she plans his life; when he chooses the riding school in Salisbury she goes to London to bring him back to her plans.

3. **Tragedy:** his death shows the cost of her possessive love, and contrasts with how she later lets Doris go.

Marking tip: comparing Richard with Doris shows you understand the play's message about letting go.

Why does Kon tell the story through only one actress? Explain two effects.

1. We hear only Emily's side, so she is an **unreliable narrator**: we must judge what she leaves out. 2. **Direct address** makes the audience her guests and confidants, so we feel close to her even when she is manipulative, which makes the ending more painful.

Marking tip: one mark for each effect, more for explaining it with an example from the play.

Watch out: these are plans. In the exam, turn each point into a full PEEL paragraph with a quote from the text.

Reading an unseen poem: 5 steps

METHOD

1. **Title:** what does it suggest? Read the poem twice, slowly
2. **Who and what:** who is the speaker? What is happening, and where? Sum the poem up in one sentence
3. **Tone and mood:** how does the speaker feel? Does the feeling **shift**? Look for words like "but", "yet", "now", or a new stanza
4. **Techniques:** underline 3-4 striking words or images and name the technique
5. **Message:** what is the poet saying about life, people or nature?

Title → What it's about → Tone and shift → Techniques + effect → Message

Remember with SMILE: Structure, Meaning, Imagery, Language, Effect.

Watch out: you don't need to "get" every line. Write confidently about the parts you understand and use "perhaps" or "this may suggest" for the rest.

Poetry techniques and their effects

TECHNIQUES

TECHNIQUE	WHAT IT IS	EFFECT WORDS TO USE
Imagery	words that create a picture or sense	vivid, helps the reader see / hear / feel
Simile	comparison with "like" or "as"	emphasises a quality, makes it easy to picture
Metaphor	says one thing <i>is</i> another	stronger than a simile, gives new meaning
Personification	human qualities given to a thing	makes it seem alive, powerful or threatening
Alliteration	same first sound repeated	draws attention; hard sounds (k, c, t) feel harsh, soft sounds (s, m) feel gentle
Onomatopoeia	a word that sounds like its meaning	brings the scene alive through sound
Repetition	word or line repeated	emphasis, insistence, strong emotion
Rhyme and rhythm	sound pattern and beat	regular = calm, controlled; broken = tension
Enjambment	sentence runs over the line break	speed, flow, or an idea that can't be held back
Caesura	pause in the middle of a line (punctuation)	slows us down, stresses a word, hesitation
Contrast	two opposite ideas placed together	highlights a difference or a change
Symbol	object standing for an idea	adds deeper meaning (e.g. a bird for hope or freedom)

Watch out: "the poet uses alliteration" scores nothing on its own. Say **which words**, and what the sound or picture **makes the reader feel**.

Words for tone and mood

TONE

FEELING	TONE WORDS
Happy	joyful, celebratory, light-hearted, hopeful, admiring
Sad	melancholic, mournful, regretful, nostalgic, lonely
Angry	bitter, resentful, indignant, frustrated
Calm	peaceful, gentle, reflective, thoughtful
Fearful	anxious, tense, uneasy, threatening, ominous
Strong	confident, defiant, determined, proud
Mocking	sarcastic, ironic, humorous

- **Tone** = the speaker's attitude. **Mood** = the atmosphere the reader feels
- Describe a **shift**: "The tone changes from hopeful to regretful in stanza 3, when..."

Watch out: avoid vague words like "sad" or "happy" alone. Pick a precise word and back it up with a quote.

Structure and form

STRUCTURE

- **Stanzas:** how many, and does each one move the poem on (a new idea, time or feeling)?
- **Line length:** short lines are quick or abrupt; long lines are slow or flowing
- **Punctuation:** dashes, question marks and exclamations show hesitation, doubt or emotion
- **Opening and ending:** compare them. What has changed? Is the ending a surprise, a lesson or a question?
- **Free verse** (no regular rhyme or rhythm) can feel natural and like speech; a **regular pattern** can feel controlled or song-like

EXAMPLE SENTENCE

"The poem ends with a short, separate line, which makes the final image stand out and leaves the reader thinking about the speaker's loss."

Watch out: only write about structure if you can say its effect. Counting stanzas is not analysis.

Writing your poetry answer

ANSWERS

Both parts are compulsory. Usually there are shorter questions on meaning and language, then a longer question on how the poet presents an idea.

QUESTION TYPE

HOW TO ANSWER

"What do you learn about...?"	one point per mark, each with a short quote
"What is the effect of...?" / "Explain the image..."	name the technique, quote it, explain what it suggests and how it makes the reader feel
"How does the poet present...?" (longer)	3 PEEL paragraphs moving through the poem in order, including the tone shift and the ending

PEEL PARAGRAPH FRAME

The poet presents [idea] as [adjective] [point]. This is seen in "[short quote]" [evidence]. The word "[one word]" suggests... which makes the reader feel... [explain]. This shows that... [link to question].

Watch out: write in the present tense and about "the poet" or "the speaker", not "I think the poem is nice".

The Eagle (Tennyson)

POEM 1

He clasps the crag with crooked hands;
Close to the sun in lonely lands,
Ring'd with the azure world, he stands.

The wrinkled sea beneath him crawls;
He watches from his mountain walls,
And like a thunderbolt he falls.

"The Eagle", Alfred, Lord Tennyson (1851)

What impressions of the eagle does the poet create in the first stanza?

The eagle seems **powerful and old**: "clasps" with "crooked hands" suggests a strong grip, like an old man's. It seems **isolated and noble**: "lonely lands" and "Close to the sun" show it lives high above everything, almost like a king.

Marking tip: two impressions, each supported with a quote and explained.

How does the poet use sound and imagery to make the eagle seem powerful?

The hard "c" alliteration in "clasps the crag with crooked hands" sounds harsh and gripping, matching the eagle's strength. Personification gives it "hands", making it seem almost human and in control. From its height, "The wrinkled sea beneath him crawls": the sea, normally mighty, seems small and weak, which shows how far above the world the eagle is. The simile "like a thunderbolt he falls" ends the poem with sudden, violent speed, showing its deadly power.

Marking tip: name each technique, quote it, then explain the effect. Three developed points beat six named techniques.

Comment on the structure of the poem.

Two stanzas of three lines, each with one rhyme sound (hands / lands / stands; crawls / walls / falls). The first stanza is still: the eagle "stands". The second ends in sudden movement: he "falls". This contrast between stillness and the final dive makes the ending dramatic.

Marking tip: link the structure to meaning: still → sudden action.

Watch out: "azure" means sky-blue. If you meet a word you don't know, work it out from context instead of skipping the line.

"Hope" is the thing with feathers -
That perches in the soul -
And sings the tune without the words -
And never stops - at all -

And sweetest - in the Gale - is heard -
And sore must be the storm -
That could abash the little Bird
That kept so many warm -

I've heard it in the chilliest land -
And on the strangest Sea -
Yet - never - in Extremity,
It asked a crumb - of me.

"Hope is the thing with feathers", Emily Dickinson (published 1891)

What is hope compared to, and why is this effective?

Hope is an extended **metaphor** for a small bird that "perches in the soul". A bird is small and light but keeps singing, which suggests hope is gentle yet always present inside us. It "sings the tune without the words": hope is a feeling we can't always explain.

Marking tip: identify the metaphor, then explain at least two ways the bird is like hope.

How does the poet show that hope is strong even in hard times?

"sweetest - in the Gale": hope sounds best during a storm, so it is strongest when life is hardest. "sore must be the storm / That could abash the little Bird" means only a terrible storm could silence it, stressing its toughness. It "kept so many warm", showing it comforts many people. Finally, it "never" asked "a crumb": hope gives everything and asks for nothing. The dashes slow the reader down and stress key words like "never".

Marking tip: move through the poem in order and include the ending; comment on the dashes for a structure point.

Describe the tone of the poem.

The tone is **hopeful and admiring**. The speaker praises hope gently, and in the last stanza becomes personal and grateful ("I've heard it").

Marking tip: a precise tone word, a quote, and a mention of the shift to the personal "I".

Watch out: stay with the metaphor. Every detail (feathers, singing, storm, crumb) is about hope, not a real bird.

Who has seen the wind?
Neither I nor you:
But when the leaves hang trembling,
The wind is passing through.

Who has seen the wind?
Neither you nor I:
But when the trees bow down their heads,
The wind is passing by.

"Who Has Seen the Wind?", Christina Rossetti (1872)

What is the effect of the repeated question?

Repeating "Who has seen the wind?" at the start of each stanza makes the poem sound like a riddle or a song. The answer, "Neither I nor you", reminds us that the wind is invisible, so it makes the reader think about things we can't see but know are real.

Marking tip: explain both the sound effect (song or riddle) and the idea it raises.

How does the poet show the wind's presence even though it cannot be seen?

The poet shows the wind through its **effects**. Personification: "the leaves hang trembling" suggests the leaves are nervous or afraid, so the wind seems mysterious and powerful. "the trees bow down their heads" shows the trees bowing as if to a king, showing the wind's power and importance. The word "But" in both stanzas turns from what we can't see to what we can. The poem may suggest that unseen things such as love or faith can be known by their effects.

Marking tip: two developed points on personification, plus one on the wider meaning, scores well.

Watch out: a "deeper meaning" must come from the poem. Use "may suggest" and link it to words in the text.